

Altars

This document about **Altars** explains what they are, how they were made, their purpose, and their significance in both the Old and New Testaments.

- Altars were **designed for sacrifice** and could be **made of earth or unhewn stone**.

Altars of brick were hateful to God. Natural rocks were sometimes used as altars.

- Altars should not have steps leading up to them.
- Altars used for **idolatrous worship** were often erected on the roofs of houses and had groves of trees planted near them. The Israelites were commanded to destroy these altars.
- **Inscriptions** were sometimes written on altars.

The document also includes a **list of specific altars** mentioned in the Bible, including those built by Noah, Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, Balaam, Joshua, Solomon, and others.

Finally, the document describes **different types of altars** used for burnt offerings and incense, as well as the **protection** they afforded to those who sought refuge there. However, altars did not offer protection to murderers.

Designed for sacrifice.

Exodus 20:24. An altar of earth thou shalt make unto me, and shalt sacrifice thereon thy Burnt Offerings, and thy Peace Offerings, thy sheep, and thine oxen: in all places where I record my name I will come unto thee, and I will bless thee.

To be made of earth, or unhewn stone.

Exodus 20:24-25. An altar of earth thou shalt make unto me, and shalt sacrifice thereon thy Burnt Offerings, and thy Peace Offerings, thy sheep, and thine oxen: in all places where I record my name I will come unto thee, and I will bless thee. And if thou wilt make me an altar of stone, thou shalt not build it of hewn stone: for if thou lift up thy tool upon it, thou hast polluted it.

Of brick, hateful to God.

Isaiah 65:3. A people that provoketh me to Anger continually to my face; that sacrificeth in gardens, and burneth incense upon Altars of brick;

Natural rocks sometimes used as.

Judges 6:19-21. And Gideon went in, and made ready a kid, and unleavened cakes of an ephah of flour: the flesh he put in a basket, and he put the broth in a pot, and brought it out unto him under the oak, and presented it. And the angel of God said unto him, Take the flesh and the unleavened cakes, and lay them upon this rock, and pour out the broth. And he did so. Then the angel of the LORD put forth the end of the staff that was in his hand, and touched the flesh and the unleavened cakes; and there rose up fire out of the rock, and consumed the flesh and the unleavened cakes. Then the angel of the LORD departed out of his sight.

Judges 13:19-20. So Manoah took a kid with a meat offering, and offered it upon a rock unto the LORD: and the angel did wondrously; and Manoah and his wife looked on. For it came to pass, when the flame went up toward heaven from off the altar, that the angel of the LORD ascended in the flame of the altar. And Manoah and his wife looked on it, and fell on their faces to the ground.

Were not to have steps up to them.

Exodus 20:26. Neither shalt thou go up by steps unto mine altar, that thy nakedness be not discovered thereon.

For idolatrous worship, often erected on roofs of houses.

2 Kings 23:12. And the Altars that were on the top of the upper chamber of Ahaz, which the kings of Judah had made, and the Altars which Manasseh had made in the two courts of the house of the LORD, did the king beat down, and brake them down from thence, and cast the dust of them into the brook Kidron.

Jeremiah 19:13. And the houses of Jerusalem, and the houses of the kings of Judah, shall be defiled as the place of Tophet, because of all the houses upon whose roofs they have burned incense unto all the host of heaven, and have poured out drink offerings unto other gods.

Jeremiah 32:29. And the Chaldeans, that fight against this city, shall come and set fire on this city, and burn it with the houses, upon whose roofs they have offered incense unto Baal, and poured out drink offerings unto other gods, to provoke me to Anger.

Idolaters planted groves near.

Judges 6:30. Then the men of the city said unto Joash, Bring out thy son, that he may die: because he hath cast down the altar of Baal, and because he hath cut down the grove that was by it.

1 Kings 16:32-33. And he reared up an altar for Baal in the house of Baal, which he had built

in Samaria. And Ahab made a grove; and Ahab did more to provoke the LORD God of Israel to Anger than all the kings of Israel that were before him.

2 Kings 21:3. For he built up again the high places which Hezekiah his Father had destroyed; and he reared up Altars for Baal, and made a grove, as did Ahab king of Israel; and worshipped all the host of heaven, and served them.

The Jews not to plant groves near.

Deuteronomy 16:21. Thou shalt not plant thee a grove of any trees near unto the altar of the LORD thy God, which thou shalt make thee.

For idolatrous worship, to be destroyed.

Exodus 34:13. But ye shall destroy their Altars, break their Images, and cut down their Groves:

Deuteronomy 7:5. But thus shall ye deal with them; ye shall destroy their Altars, and break down their Images, and cut down their Groves, and burn their graven Images with fire.

Probable origin of inscriptions on.

Deuteronomy 27:8. And thou shalt write upon the stones all the words of this law very plainly.

MENTIONED IN SCRIPTURE;

Of Noah.

Genesis 8:20. And Noah builded an altar unto the LORD; and took of every clean beast, and of every clean fowl, and offered Burnt Offerings on the altar.

Of Abraham.

Genesis 12:7. And the LORD appeared unto Abram, and said, Unto thy seed will I give this land: and there builded he an altar unto the LORD, who appeared unto him.

Genesis 13:18. Then Abram removed his tent, and came and dwelt in the plain of Mamre, which is in Hebron, and built there an altar unto the LORD.

Genesis 22:9. And they came to the place which God had told him of; and Abraham built an altar there, and laid the wood in order, and bound Isaac his son, and laid him on the altar upon the wood.

Of Isaac.

Genesis 26:25. And he builded an altar there, and called upon the name of the LORD, and pitched his tent there: and there Isaac's servants digged a well.

Of Jacob.

Genesis 33:20. And he erected there an altar, and called it Elelohe-Israel.

Genesis 35:1. And God said unto Jacob, Arise, go up to Bethel, and dwell there: and make there an altar unto God, that appeared unto thee when thou fleddest from the face of Esau thy brother.

Genesis 35:3. And let us arise, and go up to Bethel; and I will make there an altar unto God, who answered me in the day of my distress, and was with me in the way which I went.

Genesis 35:7. And he built there an altar, and called the place Elbethel: because there God appeared unto him, when he fled from the face of his brother.

Of Moses.

Exodus 17:15. And Moses built an altar, and called the name of it Jehovahnissi:

Exodus 24:4. And Moses wrote all the words of the LORD, and rose up early in the morning, and builded an altar under the hill, and twelve pillars, according to the twelve Tribes of Israel.

Of Balaam.

Numbers 23:1. And Balaam said unto Balak, Build me here seven Altars, and prepare me here seven oxen and seven rams.

Numbers 23:14. And he brought him into the field of Zophim, to the top of Pisgah, and built seven Altars, and offered a bullock and a ram on every altar.

Numbers 23:29. And Balaam said unto Balak, Build me here seven Altars, and prepare me

here seven bullocks and seven rams.

Of Joshua.

Joshua 8:30-31. Then Joshua built an altar unto the LORD God of Israel in mount Ebal, As Moses the Servant of the LORD commanded the children of Israel, as it is written in the book of The Law of Moses, an altar of whole stones, over which no man hath lift up any iron: and they offered thereon Burnt Offerings unto the LORD, and sacrificed Peace Offerings.

Of the temple of Solomon.

2 Chronicles 4:1. Moreover he made an altar of brass, twenty cubits the length thereof, and twenty cubits the breadth thereof, and ten cubits the height thereof.

2 Chronicles 4:19. And Solomon made all the vessels that were for the house of God, the golden altar also, and the tables whereon the shewbread was set;

Of the second temple.

Ezra 3:2-3. Then stood up Jeshua the son of Jozadak, and his Brethren the priests, and Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and his Brethren, and builded the altar of the God of Israel, to offer Burnt Offerings thereon, as it is written in The Law of Moses the man of God. And they set the altar upon his bases; for fear was upon them because of the people of those countries: and they offered Burnt Offerings thereon unto the LORD, even Burnt Offerings morning and evening.

Of Reubenites, ect. East of Jordan.

Joshua 22:10. And when they came unto the borders of Jordan, that are in the land of Canaan, the children of Reuben and the children of Gad and the half tribe of Manasseh built there an altar by Jordan, a great altar to see to.

Of Gideon.

Judges 6:26-27. And build an altar unto the LORD thy God upon the top of this rock, in the ordered place, and take the second bullock, and offer a burnt sacrifice with the wood of the

grove which thou shalt cut down. Then Gideon took ten men of his servants, and did as the LORD had said unto him: and so it was, because he feared his Father's household, and the men of the city, that he could not do it by day, that he did it by night.

Of the people of Israel.

Judges 21:4. And it came to pass on the morrow, that the people rose early, and built there an altar, and offered Burnt Offerings and Peace Offerings.

Of Samuel.

1 Samuel 7:17. And his return was to Ramah; for there was his house; and there he judged Israel; and there he built an altar unto the LORD.

Of David.

2 Samuel 24:21. And Araunah said, Wherefore is my lord the king come to his Servant? And David said, To buy the threshingfloor of thee, to build an altar unto the LORD, that the plague may be stayed from the people.

2 Samuel 24:25. And David built there an altar unto the LORD, and offered Burnt Offerings and Peace Offerings. So the LORD was intreated for the land, and the plague was stayed from Israel.

Of Jeroboam at Bethel.

1 Kings 12:33. So he offered upon the altar which he had made in Bethel the fifteenth day of the eighth month, even in the month which he had devised of his own heart; and ordained a feast unto the children of Israel: and he offered upon the altar, and burnt incense.

Of Ahaz.

2 Kings 16:10-12. And king Ahaz went to Damascus to meet Tiglathpileser king of Assyria, and saw an altar that was at Damascus: and king Ahaz sent to Urijah the priest the fashion of the altar, and the pattern of it, according to all the workmanship thereof. And Urijah the priest built an altar according to all that king Ahaz had sent from Damascus: so Urijah the priest made

it against king Ahaz came from Damascus. And when the king was come from Damascus, the king saw the altar: and the king approached to the altar, and offered thereon.

Of the Athenians.

Acts 17:23. For as I passed by, and beheld your devotions, I found an altar with this inscription, TO THE UNKNOWN GOD. Whom therefore ye ignorantly worship, him declare I unto you.

For burnt-offering.

Exodus 27:1-8. And thou shalt make an altar of shittim wood, five cubits long, and five cubits broad; the altar shall be foursquare: and the height thereof shall be three cubits. And thou shalt make the horns of it upon the four corners thereof: his horns shall be of the same: and thou shalt overlay it with brass. And thou shalt make his pans to receive his ashes, and his shovels, and his basons, and his fleshhooks, and his firepans: all the vessels thereof thou shalt make of brass. And thou shalt make for it a grate of network of brass; and upon the net shalt thou make four brasen rings in the four corners thereof. ...

For incense.

Exodus 30:1-6. And thou shalt make an altar to burn incense upon: of shittim wood shalt thou make it. A cubit shall be the length thereof, and a cubit the breadth thereof; foursquare shall it be: and two cubits shall be the height thereof: the horns thereof shall be of the same. And thou shalt overlay it with pure gold, the top thereof, and the sides thereof round about, and the horns thereof; and thou shalt make unto it a crown of gold round about. And two golden rings shalt thou make to it under the crown of it, by the two corners thereof, upon the two sides of it shalt thou make it; and they shall be for places for the staves to bear it withal. ...

Protection afforded by.

1 Kings 1:50-51. And Adonijah feared because of Solomon, and arose, and went, and caught hold on the horns of the altar. And it was told Solomon, saying, Behold, Adonijah feareth king

Solomon: for, lo, he hath caught hold on the horns of the altar, saying, Let king Solomon swear unto me to day that he will not slay his Servant with the sword.

Afforded no protection to murderers.

Exodus 21:14. But if a man come presumptuously upon his neighbour, to slay him with guile; thou shalt take him from mine altar, that he may die.

1 Kings 2:18-34. And Bathsheba said, Well; I will speak for thee unto the king. Bathsheba therefore went unto king Solomon, to speak unto him for Adonijah. And the king rose up to meet her, and bowed himself unto her, and sat down on his throne, and caused a seat to be set for the king's mother; and she sat on his right hand. Then she said, I desire one small petition of thee; I pray thee, say me not nay. And the king said unto her, Ask on, my mother: for I will not say thee nay. And she said, Let Abishag the Shunammite be given to Adonijah thy brother to wife. ...